

JOANNA DAVIDSON
Boston University

The problem of widows

ABSTRACT

How does an ethnographer inquire about a social category that is neither named nor recognized as such? The Ejamat Jola language has no word for *widow*, even though more than a third of households in the Jola villages of Guinea-Bissau are occupied by women whose husbands have died. Over years of fieldwork, I have tried to explain why widows were not named or even seen by Jola villagers. Chronicling how each of my explanations was undercut by both Jola responses and my own critical scrutiny, I recount the impasses of an ethnographic quest and show the gradual process of gaining insight into experiences that cannot be encapsulated by either local or anthropological models. The unspeakable can signal not only profound fragilities in social relations but also openings for new social formations beyond the normative bounds of received cultural categories. [*widows, marriage, gender, production, reproduction, silence, ethnography, Jola, Guinea-Bissau, West Africa*]

Le mot « veuve » n'a pas d'équivalent en langue diola même si plus d'un tiers des familles des villages diola en Guinée Bissau est constitué de femmes ayant perdu leur époux. Comment donc rendre compte ethnographiquement d'une catégorie sociale qui n'a pas de nom et ne jouit pas de reconnaissance au sein d'un groupe? Au fil d'années passées sur le terrain, j'ai essayé d'expliquer dans mes productions scientifiques pourquoi les veuves demeurent une catégorie non nommée voire invisible pour les villageois diolas. Cet article est d'abord une chronique de la façon dont mes interlocuteurs diolas ainsi que mon propre jugement critique m'ont poussé à revoir chacune des explications que j'ai cherché à proposer. J'y expose les impasses d'une quête ethnographique et retrace le processus par lequel on saisit graduellement des réalités qui ne sont prises en charge ni par les schèmes autochtones ni par les théories anthropologiques. Je démontre ainsi que l'indicible peut permettre non seulement d'appréhender la fragilité de relations sociales mais aussi qu'il peut être le socle de nouvelles structures non conformes aux catégories sociales traditionnelles. [*veuves, mariage, genre, production, reproduction, silence, ethnographie, Diola, Guinée Bissau, Afrique de l'Ouest*]

Most of us, given a choice between chaos and naming . . . would choose naming. Most of us see this as a zero-sum game—as if there were no third place to be: something without a name is commonly thought not to exist. And here is where we may be able to discern the benevolence of the untranslatable. Translation is a practice, a strategy . . . that does not seem to give us a third place to be. In the presence of a word that stops itself, in that silence, one has the feeling that something has passed us and kept going, that some possibility has got free.

Anne Carson (2014, 26)

Silence is as much a part of history as noise; the invisible as much a part of history as the visible.

Max Picard (2002, 73)

Salman Rushdie (1983) famously quipped that the key to any society is in its untranslatable words. I begin here not with an untranslatable word but with an absent one, a word to name a significant segment of a population, what you and I would call widows. More than a third of households in the Jola villages of rural Guinea-Bissau are widows' houses. Although there is no word for *widow* in the Jola language, there is a word for the houses in which women reside after their deceased husband's house is torn down.¹ Perhaps there is no word for *widow* because these houses, called *kungomaku* (sing. *hungomahu*), and the women who reside in them have, for reasons I discuss below, proliferated only recently.² But such an explanation fails to account for a range of dynamics involving women who live in *kungomaku* (who do not see themselves as part of a category into which most women eventually enter), as well as their Jola neighbors and kin (who seem not to see these women at all).

I have been intrigued, perplexed, and troubled by widows since early in my fieldwork among Jola villagers in Guinea-Bissau. My initial fieldwork focused on Jola responses to the substantial changes underway in the region that made it increasingly difficult for villagers to lead a life embedded in the rice-based agrarian economy they had developed—and still clung to dearly—over many centuries (Davidson 2016). As my research documented and analyzed these transformations, widows kept cropping up in other things I was writing about—like secrecy, work, and development—but they often appeared as a poignant illustration, an extreme case, or an abstruse exception to whatever else I was talking

about. I found myself stymied again and again when I tried to make sense of widowhood itself, or, to be more precise, the increase in widowhood along with its seeming invisibility and unspeakability. My attempts over the years to solve the problem of widows were thwarted by contradictory statements among Jola themselves, or they came up short when I subjected them to my own critical scrutiny. I eventually found it helpful to engage in a kind of negative dialectics (Adorno 2007), emphasizing both the limits of knowledge itself and opening up the possibility that the outcome of the dialectical process—still valuable as an explanatory mode—may not be inexorably positive. In this case, the dialectical approach has highlighted the sense of elusiveness that characterizes Jola (and perhaps all) lifeworlds, and it has obligated me to relinquish my quest for a kind of causality and certainty that is ultimately inimical to contending with both ideological and real-world complexity. Instead, I have chosen to chronicle a series of explanations—my own and those of my interlocutors—each reaching its (often frustrating) limit, but each still cleaving at least partially or provisionally to some facet of the truth. This article, then, is as much about Jola widows as it is a “study of explanation” (Bateson 1958, 280). It grapples—methodologically, analytically, and narratively—with unknowability, which is a peculiar kind of Jola problem (Davidson 2010) and, of course, a deeply anthropological one too. It is, in a sense, about the knowing of problems and the problem of knowing.

As the plot unfolds, I hope to convey, simultaneously, how women who live in *kungomaku* present a problem for Jola society and how these same women might expose problems for ethnography more broadly. I take readers along my own path of impasses over many years of fieldwork, gradually gaining insights into experiences that could not be encapsulated by either local or anthropological models of marriage and sociality. Sometimes, anthropology allows us to pass through the looking glass of normative discourse, conventional wisdom, and customary rationales, and see how, although lives are steeped in and shaped by these factors, they are also realized independently of them. Such understandings offer glimpses of potentially liberating possibilities that may lie in unexpected places. They also further the liberating potential of ethnography itself as provocation and thought experiment, an exercise in edification (Rorty 1979) rather than certitude or closure, and an invitation to “step off a narrow path in which alternatives to our own phrasings are simply meaningless or merely poetic” (Gay y Blasco and Wardle 2007, 197).

Lost in translation

Let me start back where I empirically started, in the first flush of dissertation fieldwork in 2001 in rural Guinea-Bissau. When I moved to Esana,³ a village of about 2,000 mostly Jola residents, I kept getting lost. As I wandered

around the village, often in circles, I began to notice small houses that looked a bit different from those I had already become accustomed to as “typical” Jola houses. Typical Jola houses were rectangular, with small window openings, a front and back door, and a heavily thatched roof. The atypical houses had all these elements, but they were smaller, shabbier, not quite the same. I was told that these houses were *kungomaku* (see Figure 1).

Shortly after these initial wanderings, I began to conduct a village-wide household survey. I learned from the various companions who walked around with me as I jotted down the names of each house’s occupants that the inhabitants of these *kungomaku* were *solteiras*. *Solteira* is a Portuguese and Guinean Creole (Kriyol) word used to designate unmarried female status: a single woman. I was curious about why there were so many single women living in their own houses, especially when I started to meet some of them and realized that they ranged in age and that many of them had young children. A few conversations cleared this up when it became evident that these were, of course, widows’ houses, and their occupants were the widows, and often children, of a deceased man from that compound’s lineage.

That the Jola language has no word for *widow* is not so uncommon across Africa, and perhaps elsewhere. What a widow is called tends to reflect local understandings of life and death; so, for example, a Luo widow is *chi liel*—*wife* of the grave, not *widow* of the grave, because she is still married to her dead husband (Kirwen 1979; Potash 1986c). Among Jola, women whose husbands have died, and men whose wives have died, were referred to in the same way as other women and men their age, relative to who was addressing them (*ayó* for older women, *ampom* for older men). Sometimes widows and widowers were described as *apañorol akem*, meaning “his or her spouse died,” but this was not used as a title or designation so much as a description.

The lack of a word for *widow* does not reflect a general paucity of marriage-related vocabulary in the Jola language; indeed, there is a plethora of Jola words referring to a range of marital, nonmarital, and postmarital states. For instance, *akutuwateruh* refers to a man or woman who does not have a spouse, which might include English words such as *bachelor*, *spinster*, and *divorcé/divorcée*. This word was sometimes used to refer to a woman whose husband had died, but only if she was considered “too old” to marry again, hinting at a division between postmenopausal and reproductive-age widows. Postmenopausal women whose husbands had died sometimes went to *karonaku*—living in the house of a married son or brother—rather than residing in her own *hungomahu*. Before the increase in *kungomaku*, reproductive-age widows were typically remarried to one of their deceased husband’s agnates, a practice that Jola call *butunorabu*.⁴



Figure 1. A *hungomahu* (“widow’s” house) in the Jola village of Esana, Guinea-Bissau, March 2016. [This figure appears in color in the online issue]

Elsewhere in Guinea-Bissau, Kriyol speakers used the word *viuva*—a more precise match for the English word *widow*. But when Kriyol speakers in Jola-land referred to the inhabitants of *kungomaku*, they called them *solteiras*, not *viuvas*. Perhaps because *viuva* has no corresponding word in Jola, they opted for *solteira* as a recognizable “unmarried female” term. Or perhaps—I thought, as I began to get a sense of the circumstances of widows’ lives—they were signaling some aspects of a widow’s experience, since *solteira* derives from root words that mean “single” and “alone.”

So that is what I had so far: no Jola word for *widow*, but a word for their houses. The Jola word for a typical house is *elupay* (pl. *silupasu*), which also means family. Building an *elupay* represents a young man’s most concrete move toward adult status, whether or not he has been ritually initiated. That the word for *family* and *house* is the same reveals the extent to which the two are inextricably tied as relatively autonomous units for producing, consuming, and decision-making. Designating a widow’s house as *hungomahu* emphasizes its difference and distance from the family-based

elupay. When a man dies, his *elupay* is torn down about a year after his death, and his widow’s *hungomahu* is built in her virilocal neighborhood, often adjacent to where the destroyed *elupay* once stood (see Figure 2). In some cases, if she has no kin to help her, she builds her own house. During my first dry season in Esana, I saw a young woman whose husband had died build a *hungomahu* completely by herself (a task that, even for men, is a collective activity). This woman constructed her *hungomahu* on borrowed land across the road from my host family’s house in an area of the village with much foot traffic. No neighbors or passersby offered to help with the arduous work. I asked the mother of my host family—a good friend of this woman and a co-member of a women’s work association with her—why she was building her house all by herself. She replied, “What choice does she have? Who would help her, and risk other people talking? We Jola, we’re difficult. Everyone has to fend for themselves.”

Not only is a dead man’s house torn down but his land is incorporated back into his lineage and redistributed



Figure 2. The remains of a torn-down *elupay* (family house) in Esana, Guinea-Bissau, March 2019. [This figure appears in color in the online issue]

among his agnatic kin. In Jola land-tenure practices, a woman has access to land only through her husband, and once he dies, she is no longer entitled to work in his forest grove or rice paddies. Once the husband's rice paddies have been reabsorbed into his lineage, his widow must borrow unused paddies from her own kin, a fragile and tenuous arrangement at best. If she has sons, they will inherit their share of their patrilineal land when they come of age. If she does not have grown sons or benevolent uncles who will hoe the paddy for her, she will wield the heavy fulcrum shovel herself and perform what is considered quintessentially male labor. If she cannot borrow paddy, she begs for rice. Some women whose husbands have died offer their labor to other women, helping them with the strenuous work of transplanting rice seedlings and receiving payment in harvested rice, although this work is limited to the increasingly short rainy season. Sometimes a widow's grown children provide her with a small quantity of rice; sometimes neighbors send over some rice. One widow with several young children told me that she regularly did not eat

all day (see Figure 3). As with other women in *kungomaku* I came to know, her main efforts were to *kuji-kuji*—that is, to produce or acquire any small quantity of goods (palm oil, chili peppers, eggs) that she could trade or sell for rice to feed the smallest children in her household. On a hot day during the dry season, she told me,

I have these young children here. But early in the morning, I don't let them leave the house. [...] Because if they go off, they will see that other people are eating rice for breakfast, and they will see that we have nothing. [...] So I keep them here until others are finished eating, and then I let them go.

After I completed collecting information for the household survey, I tabulated the results and was surprised to find that of the Jola households in each traditional neighborhood, an average of 34 percent were *kungomaku*. Again, like the lack of a specific word for *widow*, this proportion of widows, I found out later, was quite common across rural Africa (Cattell 2003; Mutongi 2007; Potash 1986b). At the time,



Figure 3. A woman and one of her children stand outside her *hungomahu* (“widow’s” house) in Esana, Guinea-Bissau, March 2019. [This figure appears in color in the online issue]

however, I did not know that this was common, so my initial questions focused on why such a seemingly significant proportion of Jola houses were *kungomaku*. Were women simply outliving men? Was this a new phenomenon, or was the proportion of *kungomaku* as compared to *silupas* the same as it had been for many years? And how were Jola reconciling what seemed like the extreme poverty of women who lived in *kungomaku* with their generalized claims about economic parity across all households? In posing these questions, I immediately cast widows as a problem.⁵

And, at first, my most trusted interlocutors in Esana seemed to agree with my framing. For example, when I commented on the surprising number of *kungomaku* to my friend Tegilosso, he explained it as a consequence of recently eroded *butunorabu* practices of remarriage. “Now there are more *kungomaku* than before,” he said. “Before, if a man died, a woman would be obliged to marry again. [. . .] But now, women refuse to remarry, so there are more *kungomaku* than before.” When I discussed the matter with other residents in Esana, some agreed that, now, “women refuse to remarry.” Others pointed to the current economic impossibility of a man taking on a second wife and her children: “When you cannot put rice in your own children’s mouths, how can you bring others into your *elupay*?” But whatever my interlocutors identified as the primary reason for eroding *butunorabu* practices—be it women’s or men’s refusal, changing attitudes and norms around gender and marriage, or Jolas’ increasing poverty and decreasing ability to sustain their families—everyone seemed surprised that there were so many *kungomaku*. They clearly did not know about either the quantity or the intensity of widows’ predicament.

This reaction motivated and textured my ongoing preoccupation with women who lived in *kungomaku*, a preoccupation that, during my dissertation fieldwork, was undergirded primarily by a humanitarian perspective. Observing that my household survey data were a surprise to Esana’s Jola and non-Jola residents alike, I cast my role in Freirian terms; surely, once others realized the magnitude and intensity of the problem, they would come up with culturally appropriate ways to resolve it. After all, as Tegilosso had pointed out, this was not an endemic problem per se. Such was my first take on “the problem of widows.” I continued to gather information, conduct many frustrating and seemingly fruitless interviews with women who lived in *kungomaku*, and jot down anything I heard from anyone else talking about a particular woman whose husband had died or about *kungomaku* residents in general (although such talk, because no one recognized them as an actual category, was exceedingly rare and usually a consequence of my prompting). All this led to my first tenaciously held explanation of the problem of widows, which went something like this: Widows were an extremely vulnerable

and numerically significant segment of the population, yet one that Jola still did not recognize as such. Their numbers were growing because of increasing general poverty and eroding *butunorabu* practices. *Butunorabu* had provided a well-integrated safety net for women whose husbands had died within the context of Jola social organization, kinship norms, and land-tenure practices. The increase in *kungomaku* appeared to result from uneven change. *Butunorabu* practices had eroded without concurrent shifts in linked customs, such as breaking down a man’s *elupay*, reclaiming his agricultural landholdings, and redistributing them only to married sons with their own households. If the increase in *kungomaku* was seen and understood as an unwitting negative consequence of economic and cultural plate tectonics, people would develop new social safety nets in line with general Jola mores that emphasize a rough economic equality.

But calling attention to these women and their severe circumstances did not yield the reactions and responses I expected. And the longer I stayed, and especially over subsequent years and periodic visits, what I was hearing and gathering just did not add up.

For example, when I increasingly brought up the topic of women who lived in *kungomaku* to my friends and neighbors in casual conversations, they often responded with a comment or anecdote about a particular woman whose husband had died, but they almost never talked about widowhood. My interlocutors had no problem recognizing the extreme poverty of the women I mentioned, but they did not recognize that they themselves (or their mothers, sisters, or wives) were or could be in the same situation. The number of *kungomaku*, even when exposed, did not change this atomized view of the women whom my interlocutors continued to either call *solteiras* or refer to by their personal names.

Women who lived in *kungomaku* even viewed themselves in this light. After getting to know several of them independently and becoming increasingly aware of and concerned about their austere conditions, I asked one woman with several young children in her *hungomahu* whether she spoke to other women in *kungomaku* about their shared situation and whether she thought about joining with them to collectively address their common problems. She looked at me blankly. I tried to explain that there were many women who were dealing with the same problems: women whose husbands had died, who had no access to land, who struggled to feed themselves and their children. I asked if they talked about such things, perhaps when visiting each other or when attending the same event, like a funeral. Her response was unequivocal: “We do not talk about such things. [. . .] For us, it is a secret.” “Poverty is a secret?” I asked. “Yes,” she responded. “For you to tell someone, ‘Today I don’t have this or that,’ he’ll listen to you, but won’t give you anything. That’s why, in this sense, I

stay alone with this poverty. That's why I don't tell anyone." In many subsequent discussions with women who lived in *kungomaku*, they stressed to me that they did not talk with others, even other *kungomaku* dwellers, about their hardships and struggles to survive.

In one neighborhood there was an entire cluster of *kungomaku*: five small houses whose residents were within earshot of each other. But what I initially saw as a widow's neighborhood ripe for collective action, or at least mutual assistance, Jola literally did not see. I counted them, showed the results to widows themselves and their married neighbors, and they were impressed: "Huh! We never noticed." Much later, this episode came back to me when I was reading Anne Carson's (2014, 18) discussion of the painter Francis Bacon, who once said, "We nearly always live through screens—a screened existence." Screens, Carson elaborated, are "part of our normal way of looking at the world, or rather, our normal way of seeing the world without looking at it. . . . Screens are in place making it hard to see anything but what one expects to see" (18, 24).

Back in Guinea-Bissau, I was sitting with my host family one evening after consuming the contents of our collective rice bowl, and I remarked that it was interesting that leveling practices were targeted at those who had more, but those who had less—like women who lived in *kungomaku*—were not helped to reach the same level as others. The father of my host family, Ampa Badji, agreed, and said that others were left below the norm so that "people can laugh at them and their poverty." But then he immediately brought up the example of Nhamae, a woman whose husband had died several years earlier. It was good, he said, that all her children had scattered and refused to give her anything, because now she has learned to work. She used to cultivate a little upland rice, because her younger brother had given her some of his forestland. But after a week of work she would complain and not work for a month. Even worse, Ampa Badji continued,

Nhamae used to beg for rice and palm wine from Nho Keboral [Ampa Badji's wife], but when Nho Keboral gave her these things [. . .] Nhamae would never offer to help Nho Keboral transplant rice seedlings. But now that her children are not sending her anything, she is working more, and this is good.

What struck me about Ampa Badji's comments at the time was how our conversation about contradictions in Jola rhetorical (and, in other instances, practiced) commitments to parity turned into a lesson on self-reliance, laziness, and work ethic (for elaborations on Jola leveling practices, see Davidson 2009, 2016). When I pointed out what I perceived as a contradiction between Jolas' self-professed ideals of an "equal" society and the starkly unequal position of widows, conversations turned quite quickly to themes pertaining to work ethic.

It is important to note that widows' poverty was, in fact, an extreme form of a general problem. Most families in Esana were involved in the same kind of day-to-day struggle to survive as were women who lived in *kungomaku*. Even households with healthy adults, access to abundant land, and combined male and female labor power rarely produced enough rice to feed their members throughout the year. A middle-aged man in Esana once told me, "*Solteiras* [referring to women who lived in *kungomaku*] have an even better life than us, because they have a special way of economizing. Rice that won't last more than a day in my house will last a *solteira* several days, because they have a special manner of stretching such things out." I initially dismissed this statement as perverse, but later came to see how much it reflected Jola reasoning.

For now, though, it seemed that the women you and I would call widows refused to be categorized or even named as such, and that other Esana residents increasingly emphasized (or at least hinted at) other dimensions—like work ethic and a "special way of economizing"—over and above eroding *butunorabu* practices. And as I later read more about widows elsewhere, the biases and limits of my own first impressions, even when seemingly corroborated by at least some of my Jola interlocutors, became embarrassingly clear. For instance, Betty Potash's (1986b) edited volume on African widows empirically demonstrated across a range of case studies that—contrary to conventional assumptions—there was no widespread communal support for widows; rather, self-reliance was typical (see also Davison 1996, 154–56). So my own naive notion that widows were "dependents who in preindustrial societies are provided for by communal kin institutions" (Potash 1986a, 27), such as the levirate, was—as Potash argued—baseless.

Duly chastised, I moved on. But I still wanted to know why women who lived in *kungomaku* were reluctant to discuss their poverty, even with each other, and why Ampa Badji talked about work as an answer to my questions about economic parity. So in talking about these women with other Esana residents, I moved from my own narrow understanding of widows as an exclusive category of humanitarian concern, or even as casualties of cultural plate tectonics, to a deeper appreciation of what equality might mean in Jola terms. This eventually led to my next attempted explanation, which also turned out to be not quite right, but at least not as flawed as my previous one.

My revised understanding of the problem of widows pointed to a distinction between two kinds of equality in Jola society: an equality of goods and an equality of action. The first—equality of goods—entailed the kinds of secrecy, surveillance, jealousy, leveling practices, and performed poverty quite common in many agrarian societies like that of the Jola. The second—equality of action—was reflected in the range of responses to my insistence that women who lived in *kungomaku* be distinguished and named as a

problem. My interlocutors repeatedly returned to activities and experiences that define all Jola adults: arduous work, self-sufficiency, and continual suffering. In their view, the fact that these women had *less* (land, rice, labor power) did not constitute a reason for “pulling them up,” because work and suffering are infinite and limitless, not quantifiable on a scale that measures material equality. The perspective that they actually had *more*, because they could make it last, demonstrated the irrelevance of the concept of quantity. In an equality-of-action framework, such differences as widowed status, gender, or access to land were likewise irrelevant, because everyone worked and everyone suffered. Also beside the point was collective action by or on behalf of women who lived in *kungomaku*. From a general Jola standpoint, there was no real problem.

When Ampa Badji answered my challenge by talking about how Nhamae’s own children refused to support her, he was signaling a more general Jola ideal of occupying—or at least creating the image that one occupies—a middle zone of self-sustenance. If one rises above this level, diffuse leveling sanctions come into play. Likewise, if—like women who lived in *kungomaku*—one falls below, the consequences are mockery and shame. Displaying or performing poverty was kept very much within the realms of expected and normative material conditions. Widows would be a problem only if they openly displayed their extreme vulnerability and poverty, either individually or collectively. They were silent about their particular kind of poverty because speaking of it would expose the shameful fact that they could not sustain themselves.

This was compounded by a particular facet of Jola social organization that placed women in a less stable position than men. Given male land inheritance and virilocal marriage, women had no permanent base, whether agricultural or residential. As one Jola respondent put it, “Women are like the wind. They can be in one place one day, but if they marry, they will be in another place, perhaps even another country, the next.” What collective organizing existed in Jola society happened very much at the neighborhood level, through a deeply place-based sense of allegiance, solidarity, and mutual commitment. Women’s mobility lent them a permanent aspect of impermanence, further contributing to the difficulty of organizing and acting collectively. So when the *kungomaku* inhabitants with whom I spoke insisted that they did not speak to or even know of each other—that is, did not know that they held circumstances in common with more than a third of Esana’s households—they were revealing both these attributes of Jola aspirational and residential norms.

Widows elsewhere

In “Belief and the Problem of Women,” Edwin Ardener (1989a, 73, 75) laments that the anthropological study of

women is tantamount to “mere bird-watching,” and that women appear in fieldnotes “in the same way as [...] the Nuer’s cows, who were observed but did not speak.” The problem, he says, is with anthropologists—even (or, he suggests, especially) female anthropologists—who cannot overcome their own attachment to a vision of society bounded from nature. Women, Ardener (1989a, 74) argues, provide models of society that “are not of the kind acceptable at first sight to men or to ethnographers. . . . To put it more simply: they will not necessarily provide a model of society as a unit that will contain both men and themselves.” Male models of society, on the other hand, fit better with what ethnographers are trained to look for, or even—as he asserts in a follow-up essay—what women ethnographers understand based on their own mutedness within their native “world-structures” (Ardener 1989b, 128–30).

Ardener’s short but powerful essay, which focuses on the asymmetrical relationships between dominant and muted groups based on the inadequacy of language, kept coming to mind as I puzzled over the problem of widows. Putting aside the more obviously outdated and essentialist aspects of the essay, the overall implication of Ardener’s perspective is still quite radical and not fully realized. Ardener (1989a, 72) insists in the first line of his essay that “the problem of women has not been solved by social anthropologists. . . . Indeed the problem itself has been often examined only to be put aside again for want of a solution, for its intractability is genuine.” As I admitted previously, I have tried on several occasions to pull widows onto center stage, but because I have been unable to do so, widows have appeared on my various pages in very much the way Ardener decried. And after developing but remaining dissatisfied with both the tectonics and the equality-of-action explanations, I put widows aside, just as Ardener predicted.

But they continued to haunt me, so I belatedly turned my attention to other scholarship on widows for help. With the exception of India, where scholarly and policy pre-occupations with widows have been extensive, the general literature on widowhood is rather scant, and more often than not a specialized concern within gerontology (e.g., Jenkins 2003; Williams, Sawyer, and Allman 2012). There is, however, a rich literature on the extremes of widowhood, sati being the most highlighted and contested case, but also child widows, AIDS widows, controversial celebrity widows, war widows, and refugees (e.g., Cattell 2003; Cohen 1992; Das 2006; Green 1999; Haram 2001; Mani 1998; Mojola 2014; Nandi 1990; Yang 1989; Zia 2016).

Since the 1970s, scholarly literature on widows themselves has fallen roughly into two camps. The first documents how widowhood produces harsh social and economic penalties, generally portraying widows as dejected victims subject to “customary injustice” (Ewelukwa 2002;

see also Owen 1996; Sossou 2002). They are wretched and abject, often cast as witches. They are structurally outcast and socially superfluous. They are sometimes dangerous and often pathetic. In this literature, there is an oft-repeated refrain that widows “suffer from a variety of controls and restrictions” (Tovar 1998, 232).

Partially as a corrective to this “widow as victim” trope, feminist scholarship in the 1980s took a more widow-centered approach that emphasized the increased autonomy of widows and showcased widows as agents with choices, often being “freer” than wives. Even in societies that heavily restrict wives, widows were shown to have relatively more autonomy. The various case studies in Potash’s (1986b) volume pushed back on the dominant negative casting of widows to argue that, in particular, “African widows tend not to be the passive objects of rules governing rights that men allegedly have to transfer women from group to group” (Slater 1986, xix). Among the Luo, Potash argued that

widows have greater freedom than wives. They determine their own domestic routines or extra-domestic activities. They alone make decisions about their children. They are free to visit friends. (Potash 1986c, 63)

Characterizing widows as either abject victims or autonomous agents, however, caricatures their status by flattening what are often complicated, multidimensional facets of widowhood. Moreover, it fails to distinguish the range of widows’ experiences even within a given society depending on such factors as class, caste, age, and whether they have children. Sarah Lamb (1999, 2000, 2001) has done the most to differentiate accounts of widowhood in India across the life course, countering both the monolithic representation of widows and the tendency to portray them as “either oppressed victims of ‘patriarchy’ or compliant followers of Hindu ‘tradition’” (Lamb 2001, 22). Lamb has instead avoided “classifying widows as a unitary group, scrutinizing the profoundly different consequences of widowhood” for young women, childless women, mothers, and senior women (Lamb 1999, 558–59; for similar insights in Africa, see Nyanzi, Emodu-Walakira, and Serwaniko 2009; Obbo 1986).

Not surprisingly, though, some common themes emerge across the literature on widows, even in markedly different contexts. There is, for example, a general emphasis on self-reliance as a defining feature of widows’ experiences (Cattell 2003; Davison 1996; Lopata 1987, 1996; Potash 1986b). There is also an elaboration of how particular attitudes and practices concerning widows reflect general social anxieties around sex and death. Widows are often seen as contaminated by their husband’s death, and the range of ritual practices in the bereavement period (or sometimes much longer) speaks to the perceived pollution

attached to widows (Whyte 1990). In some cases, widows are implicated in their husband’s death and cast as “poison brides” (Lamb 1999, 550). Jane Guyer (1986, 204) relates a mid-19th-century version of this among Beti-speaking people in colonial Cameroon: “If the husband had been an important headman, one or more of his widows were executed on the grounds of having caused his death, and it was not clear in advance who this would be.” A more recent iteration of these anxieties emerged in the era of HIV/AIDS, as widows have been imagined both as victims and perpetrators of their husband’s death based on sexual transmission (Haram 2001). Sex, more generally, is a major preoccupation undergirding perceptions and practices concerning widows, especially younger ones. There has been significant scholarly attention to the “moral panic” arising from widows’ uncontained sexuality, with detailed accounts of myriad ways to desexualize or constrain them, whether through proscribed dress and diet, restrictions on sociality, ritual cleansing, or forced remarriage (Bremmer and van den Bosch 1995; Lamb 2000). Some cases note an easy slippage between words and perceptions that conflate widows and prostitutes (Lamb 2001, 29; Nyanzi, Emodu-Walakira, and Serwaniko 2009). As we will see, this concern about widows as unmoored sexual agents subtly seeps into the Jola case as well.

Potash’s (1986b) volume on widows in Africa is still, in some ways, the standard-bearer of information and insights about widows in this part of the world. Potash and other contributors to the volume did much to challenge reigning kinship theories of the time, demonstrating the inadequacy of both descent and alliance theories to account for widows’ experiences and strategies. By debunking such theories, pointing to the ethnocentrism of conjugally focused analyses, and contesting conventional notions of household and community organization, the volume provided an important corrective to long-standing anthropological understandings of kinship and marriage, and perhaps presaged the discipline’s more recent move to emphasize relatedness over kinship (e.g., Bamford 2019; Carsten 2000, 2003; McKinnon and Cannell 2013). The volume, however, was not without its faults. Most of the contributors concluded their analyses of widows with a rather anemic general refrain: though a widow’s behavior is constrained in some ways, it is quite unconstrained in others.

Since Potash’s (1986b) volume, not much else has been said about African widows, although they have appeared as caricatures of their theorization in one or another of these ethnographic camps (see Mutongi 2007 for an exception). I have found it productive to return to Potash’s volume, which, despite its flaws, raised some important questions that remain unanswered. Addressing them may not only lead to further insights about the lives of widows in particular places, but it may also help us rethink some commonplaces in anthropology.

What do widows really want?

Discussing Mariam Slater's (1986, xxii) assertion in Potash's volume that "a kind of marriage-ism has dulled our lens for studying single women," Jaqueline Solway (1989, 804) suggests that

by questioning whether widowhood constitutes a phase or a long-term status, the volume returns to the more fundamental question [...] of whether marriage itself should be considered a permanent status or just a phase. Thus the "naturalness" of the conjugal state for adult women is challenged. The data suggest that in many African societies marriage is the ephemeral institution and it is Westerners' biases based on our own conjugally structured society that has contributed to the stereotype of the widow as marginal.

Prompted by this perspective, as well as by my ongoing reflection on what Jola women who lived in *kungomaku* and their neighbors were telling me, I developed yet another way to consider widowhood. This had to do with what might be called the fantasy—or at least the attractions—of widowhood. When Jola women who lived in *kungomaku* told me they preferred to "stay alone with their poverty," and when Jola men made cryptic remarks about *solteiras* who "refused to remarry" and were "better off than we are," perhaps that is exactly what they meant. When seen from a certain perspective, not only the "naturalness" of marriage might be challenged but also its very desirability over the long term. Maybe it was not widows but marriage, or at least remarriage, that was the problem.

In its most obvious and empirically substantiated form, such a claim might be bolstered by the relative freedom (sexual, economic, social) of widows compared with wives.⁶ But what if these more underneath, unacknowledged attractions of being a widow were really the heart of the matter? Put starkly, who really needs a husband, especially after having children? Maybe therein lies the real danger: that widowhood is not aberrant but attractive. Perhaps the scholarship that emphasized the "harsh social and economic consequences" of widowhood, casting widows as abject victims, missed the opportunity to see these consequences as disincentives to what might be a state to which women aspire (or at least fantasize about). "Better to stay alone than to marry another man": so said a Jola woman when I asked her how she managed to provide for her four children and three grandchildren, all of whom resided with her in her *hungomahu*. "Another man just makes for more work," she added. On another occasion, when I asked a woman I had known for over 15 years, whose husband had died the previous year, whether she considered getting remarried, she whispered to me, "You sit and suffer under the punishment of your husband. When he dies, why would you go get punished by another man?"

Once it occurred to me that widowhood might, in some circumstances, be desirable, I was reminded of a conversation I had in Esana several years earlier with Lamine and Ernesto, two Guinean representatives of the only national NGO active in this isolated northwestern corner of Guinea-Bissau. At the time I was still stuck in my limited understanding of widows as primarily a humanitarian problem, and I was trying to engage these two agents of social change in considering the "problem of widows." I asked them if they knew how many women were living in *kungomaku* in Esana, and when they looked puzzled, I summarized my household survey data. At first they responded much as the local Catholic mission leaders had, suggesting that it was something the World Food Program, which was beginning to develop projects in the area, could address as a special-needs case. I countered that, while that might be a productive approach in the short term, this seemed like a problem rooted in Jolas' structural inability to provide for a significant segment of their population. The problem would only get worse, I submitted, given increased male mortality because of AIDS, involvement in military campaigns, and high-risk productive activities, such as increased palm wine tapping.⁷ The problem, I continued, could not be solved with food aid, which was a highly erratic commodity as it was, and surely just a stopgap. They nodded in agreement, and Lamine (who was not Jola) became very thoughtful, murmuring that such a predicament required immediate and enduring attention. Perhaps, he brainstormed aloud, they could set up a kind of pension fund for *kungomaku* residents that could be generated by a collective contribution from all villagers. Ernesto (who was Baiote—a neighboring "cousin" ethnic group to the Jola) quickly shook his head, dismissing the idea. He insisted that if wives perceived that women who lived in *kungomaku* were getting a good deal, they would start killing their husbands. Ernesto recounted an example of such a practice in Ziguinchor, just across the Senegalese border. Several years earlier, there was an announcement that women whose husbands were performing national military service would receive full pensions, in perpetuity, if their husbands died. Supposedly, women started poisoning their husbands in droves. According to Ernesto, when the problem became too obvious to ignore, state authorities were forced to change the pension stipulations so that a widow would receive pensions for only three months after her husband's death. Only when women began to perceive that they might gain in the short term, but would be worse off in the long term, did they stop killing their husbands.⁸

At the time I was still stuck in my efforts to help solve the widow problem, so I saw Ernesto's point only as a further challenge to addressing widows' poverty because it would increase rather than diminish the overall population of widows. But, perhaps, from widows' perspectives (and as reflected in men's anxieties) this was precisely the point.

The image of superfluous husbands provokes, at first glance, an amusing and surprising jolt, in part because of the deeply ingrained dependent status often attached to wives. But if we take this possibility seriously, beyond the obvious question of what husbands are really for, perhaps we can pivot to a new perspective—one that gives us insight into how particular people experience and navigate their positions within the bounds of marital expectations. We might also be able to reconsider other moments of dramatic economic and political transformation that shake up business-as-usual gender and conjugal relations, often resulting in a sometimes comical, sometimes violent reassertion of patriarchy in the form of reining in women's sexuality and shoring up husbands' fragile and fleeting relevance (e.g., Allman 1996; Auslander 1993; Das 2006; Hodgson and McCurdy 2001; Schroeder 1996).

Most scholarship, as with my own myopic view of Jola widow's poverty, has focused on the "harsh social and economic penalties" produced by widowhood, and these penalties can indeed be severe and unfair and require our attention and concern. But perhaps we can also productively interrogate the provenance of these penalties. Why do societies create so many disincentives to remaining an unattached adult woman? Why is so much social and cultural effort put into making it less desirable for widows to remain single than to reattach (i.e., remarry)? Why would it be readily acknowledged (not just by Lamine and Ernesto, but by many other men and women) that a widow's pension fund would be enough incentive for women to murder their husbands?⁹

Writing around widows: A kaleidoscopic approach

Silence is not acoustic. It is a change of mind, a turning around.

John Cage (1991, 64)

The long process of thinking and writing (or mostly failing to write) about women who live in *kungomaku* has required me to rub up against and reconsider several central and treasured anthropological tenets. One of the animating impulses of anthropology, especially feminist anthropology, is to draw attention to the otherwise marginalized, silenced (muted), invisibilized members of a given population. This did not work, and it should not have been the presumed ethical or justifiable orientation here. Yes, women who lived in *kungomaku* could speak, but they usually chose not to. After many futile attempts to probe deeper, to push these women to talk more frankly about their situation, I felt increasingly awkward and uncomfortable pursuing them. It felt like badgering. Of course, all ethnography is a form of badgering, but this was of a different order. They did not

want to call attention to themselves; they wanted to be left alone. And this left me to pursue a technique more common in other humanistic and narratively attentive disciplines: the write-around, asking and listening to what other Jola villagers said about women who lived in *kungomaku*. This was not just a matter of politeness or feasibility, although it was partly that. It also made more sense in relation to an effort that had shifted from documenting widows' lives to, instead, trying to understand why this significant segment of the population was simultaneously visible and invisible—there being no word for *widow* but a word for their houses. But even my write-around approach could not circumvent the ultimate ethnographic conundrum; by broaching the topic of widows, I had to name something that might not emically exist. I have tried to avoid this—both in fieldwork and writing—by not even using the word *widow*, instead referring to "women who live in *kungomaku*." But not only is this cumbersome, it does not resolve the conceptual problem.

Even more confounding, in my effort to account for the increase in *kungomaku* by writing around their occupants, I found myself accumulating a growing list of cryptic comments and asymptotic explanations from various non-widowed Jola villagers, explanations that tended to deepen my confusion rather than my understanding. But as the answers and years accumulated, I began to see these responses not so much as thwarting my effort to get to the bottom of the issue (it really was turtles all the way down), but as prismatic chips in a kaleidoscope, each offering a partial but linked glimpse of various Jola views on what you or I would call widowhood.

Some Jola intimated the impact of HIV/AIDS and other STDs on women's remarriage prospects. Although no one ever named STDs directly, several respondents—men in particular—hinted at their spectral presence. For instance, a middle-aged man obliquely proffered, "Before, if your husband died, one of his brothers would seek you out for remarriage. But now he thinks, 'I don't really know why my brother died, and maybe if I marry his wife, I'll get whatever he had that killed him.'" When I responded, "You mean like AIDS?" he nodded, then changed the subject to widows' sexual lives: "Some women say they don't want to remarry but then go have affairs with much younger men, so maybe that's their reason to stay in *kungomaku*."

Other villagers continued to emphasize the general decline in economic wherewithal, which underlay both men's resistance to fulfill their obligation to marry their dead brothers' wives and women's reluctance to subject themselves and their children to second-class status in the changing economic and household structures.¹⁰ As one of my closest companions spelled out for me,

The problem is, your husband dies. His brother wants to inherit you. But you refuse because you know that

you and your children won't be treated right in his house. He has children of his own, a wife of his own. He will always favor them. Your children will be upset and always get into conflicts with him and his children. So you prefer to stay in your own *hungomahu* and with your own children and your own suffering. But your refusal to marry your husband's brother makes him mad. This rejection turns to bitterness. That's why he doesn't help you or your children. That's why he takes all his brother's land back. Because you refused.

When I pushed further and asked her why women used to accept *butunorabu*, she made explicit the link between the increase in *kungomaku* and the declining rice economy:

Because now is not like before. The rain doesn't fall, and children don't stay here to cultivate with their father and his brothers. They didn't used to scatter like they do now. Now each kid costs more money. You are going to have to look around to pay for their food, pay for school, send them rice, send them money. [...] So, if you go to *butunorabu*, your kids won't get fair treatment. That's why, today, women whose husbands have died refuse *butunorabu*. That's why there are so many *kungomaku*. Because the rain doesn't fall and children have scattered. Before, they stayed put, and it was the same for them whether they ate in their mother's house or in their paternal uncles' houses, because they would all cultivate together. [My sons] used to eat sometimes here, sometimes at [their father's brother's cowives'] houses. Because they would all cultivate in each other's paddies.

Paddy power

Certainly these explanations help elucidate the decrease in *butunorabu* practices and increase in *kungomaku* in terms of men's and women's motivations, but they do not quite get at what made it possible for women to reject their husband's brothers' proposals. It used to be (most Jola agreed) that once their husband had died, women were *obliged* to get remarried, regardless of their concerns for their own autonomy or their children's treatment. So how has their current refusal come to be exercised? To get at this, we need to reinsert questions about the increase in *kungomaku* back into the Jola rice complex. With the changing environmental conditions and, as a consequence, declining viability of a rice-based economy, there has been a significant—although barely perceptible—shift in gender-based power. Put simply, men once truly had the upper hand and could quite readily oblige would-be widows to remarry. But because the wet-rice paddies have decreased in productivity, men's power over women has eroded somewhat. In the gendered system of rice production, men are more associated with the paddies (*butonda*) and women with the forest (*butat*). Women do not exactly own the forest, but they have relative dominion over its use and products, except

for palm wine. Given the decrease in paddy use, women increasingly use the forest to plant upland rice. Of course, women and men work in both places. It is more a matter of from where each gender derives a sense of responsibility, potency, wherewithal, and power. But a peculiar kind of Jola power: a rice-based power that is subtly exercised. Men's decreasing capacity to command the *butonda* has spilled over, in some ways, to their decreasing capacity to command women. Whereas before a widowed woman would have been compelled to remarry, that kind of compulsion is no longer easily exerted—although in unstated, indirect, and very Jola ways. The decrease in men's paddy power introduced a hairline fracture into the monolith of patriarchy. And women who lived in *kungomaku* were silently slipping out of a system based on marriage, in which they produced and reproduced largely for men.

Widowhood is always inextricably connected to other aspects of marriage systems, which, in turn, are "implicated in the politics of resource control" (Guyer 1986, 218). As Guyer (1986, 219) has noted, "The central theoretical problems in interpreting the history of kinship lie in relating such apparently cumulative processes to the political structures that only partially control and direct them, and the 'practice' through which people continue to redefine their situation under shifting conditions." In this case, the practice in question is that of Jola women whose husbands have died and who choose (although that, of course, is a fraught word in this context) poverty over remarriage, preferring to "economize in their special way" rather than sign up to be wives again. Part of what is so interesting about this practice is that it both exposes marriage as a form of economic entrapment for women, and it shows that women can make (very limited) decisions about whether or not to participate.

It might be tempting to read this as a kind of feminism; it might look as if widows are giving the middle finger to male power. But it would be quite a mistaken projection to cast Jola women who live in *kungomaku* as heretofore-unrecognized feminists. Their decisions do not really express or manifest a feminist politics, nor do they seem to be about resistance or even refusal in the way Carole McGranahan (2016) has recently proposed. Rather, they are, in my best efforts to reckon with them, a kind of quiet opting out of the system. Women who live in *kungomaku* are not so much transgressive as they are digressive. They wander out of the social plot. They guard their privacy—and maybe even fortify their invisibility—in a world otherwise full of men trying to convince women to bear their children, farm their fields, and keep their houses.¹¹ Circling back to Ardener, we might say that if widows are a problem for the social order, perhaps the social order is not quite the same problem for them. And this might be precisely what is at stake when Jola widows are not (in their own language) named as such, and rebuff (by their own silence) efforts to problematize them as a category.

Decoupling production and reproduction, or the “benevolence of the untranslatable”

As I indicated at the start of this article, my aim has been to consider the “problem of widows” both as a problem posed within a specific ethnographic context and as a problem for anthropology. The effort to do full justice to people who have been, as Ardener would put it, muted or marginalized—whether in their own societies or in anthropological discourse—is connected to the wider issue of anthropology’s avoidance of areas of human experience that both ethnographers’ concepts and local concepts fail to cover because they are existential rather than normative; that is, they are ways of being rather than ways of knowing.

But ways of knowing are still crucial for understanding why it is that Jola women who live in *kungomaku* remain unnamed and perhaps even unspeakable. For Jola, these women are problematic because they are outside the fundamental functioning unit of the household’s gendered division of labor. On the one hand, they risk becoming non-self-sustaining dependents. On the other hand, in their efforts to become productive and self-sustaining, they contravene gendered categories of work and knowledge. By assuming male roles (like tilling fields or building houses), women who live in *kungomaku* occupy a murky spot on the threshold between masculine and feminine. As Nha Ceyo, a young woman whose husband had died, told me when I visited her in her *hungomahu*, “The way you see me here, it’s me who is both husband and wife, both man and woman.” Perhaps because of this disordering and disorienting position, these women are rendered unnamed and invisible, left alone and isolated in their poverty. What could express this more aptly than the unmarked woman in her *hungomahu*: the absence of the person in the place where she lives.

Yet the absence of a Jola term for *widow* reveals even more about the fragility of social relations. The shifts that make it possible for women whose husbands have died to opt out of remarriage suggest a rupture between production and reproduction within a system that has, for many centuries, held tightly to practices and values—such as *butunorabu* and a pronatalist ethic—that harness women’s labor in a male-dominated regime of rice agriculture (Meillassoux 1975). Production and reproduction have come apart for a range of reasons—some economic, some ecological. Given the decline in paddy-based rice agriculture and the introduction of modest development schemes, women now have more access to means of self-reliance. Not surprisingly, such changes are affecting marriage practices and gender relations (see Temudo 2017 for an analysis of similar dynamics among the Balanta of Guinea-Bissau). Women who live in *kungomaku*, then, represent the kernel of a new system of production and reproduction, but one that does not fit into current—although rapidly transforming—norms. They cannot be named or even seen because they

are, in a sense, an offense to the past. These women suggest a haunting of marriage because they embody the prospect of a new material formation that is working outside it. Seeing them, *really* seeing them, would make what is happening to marriage manifest, so there is a certain embarrassment in their visibility (“Huh, we never noticed!”). The outcome of exposing this is a chilling prospect: not the feminist realization of women’s power but the apprehension that fully acknowledging this open secret—that women in *kungomaku* manage, albeit precariously, as free economic and sexual actors, making husbands superfluous—would mean that the system is not just unfair but unnecessary. Of course, Jola know this is happening; they can discern its outlines and its images. But this is a form of cognition without recognition. A word for *widow*—this unfixed sexual actor who operates outside ordinary social circles and in between normative gender roles—would turn the hairline fracture into a perhaps irreparably fragmented reality. To one last time invoke Ardener’s essay—whose title I have been playing with throughout—a real inclusion of widows’ models may spell the end of, if not men themselves, at least a version of masculinity that requires a particular relationship between production and reproduction to remain intact.

Ethnographic translation is born of those “excessive remainders . . . or *wonders* that arise when worlds are . . . out of joint”; such remainders generate “*disjunctive homonymity*, that destruction of any firm sense of place that can only be resolved by the imaginative formulation of novel worldviews” (Da Col and Graeber 2011, viii; emphasis in original). Jola widows have been particularly good to think because they engender precisely this kind of disjunctive homonymity, and in doing so they have challenged me to go beyond conventional explanations of their marginalization in both Jola and anthropological discourses. Throughout this article I, along with my Jola and scholarly interlocutors, have proposed various explanations that fail to fully account for both the undeniable increase of women who live in *kungomaku* and the stubborn silence that surrounds them, yet each explanation is still part of the story. The useful pieces of each otherwise partial analytical attempt eventually add up to a synthesis of sorts that situates the increase of *kungomaku* within the interlocking ramifications that dramatic economic and ecological transformation has for gender relations, marriage, and the relation between production and reproduction. The narrative structure I have chosen takes the form of a discursive dialectic, which has enabled me to chart both a historical process underway in rural Guinea-Bissau and an ethnographic process knee-deep in untranslatable excessive remainders (“women who live in *kungomaku*”). My process has been committed to the search for novel worldviews, for that “third place”—neither here nor there—that Anne Carson evokes in this article’s epigraph and that Jola women whose husbands have died may very well bring into being.

Notes

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1. Given its nonexistence as a word and social category among Jola, I try to avoid using the word *widow* throughout this article and instead refer to "women whose husbands have died" or "women who live in *kungomaku*." Where it is impossible or undesirable to avoid the word *widow*, the reader should add imaginary scare quotes to it.

2. Until recently, there was generally only one *hungomahu*—or, at the most, two *kungomaku*—in each village neighborhood. These were occupied by a post-reproductive-age woman and temporarily housed other women from that neighborhood who had just given birth or who were in the final days of menstruating; both conditions required that women be separated from their husbands and other men. Currently, Jola use *hungomahu* to refer to any house lived in by a woman whose husband has died and who has not remarried. Each time I return to Esana I count the *kungomaku*, and each time there is a significant increase in them across all village neighborhoods. Over many years of living in and visiting Esana, I am only aware of one household composed of a man whose wife had died and who had not remarried. A consideration of men we would call widowers is beyond the scope of this article, but this would be an intriguing area for further research.

3. Esana is the Jola name for this village. All personal names in this article are pseudonyms.

4. *Butunorabu* is glossed by Jola speakers into the Kriyol word *yardansa*, which translates as "inheritance." When using the word *butunorabu*, most Jola speakers quoted or discussed in this article were referring to the long-standing (but currently diminishing) practice of women marrying one of their deceased husband's agnates.

5. One aspect of the "widow problem" that I have bracketed for the time being is the emotional dimension, including grief over lost husbands and even fear and frustration regarding their isolation. This absence reflects both Jola widows' lack of expression regarding these concerns and my decision to focus on other facets of widowhood.

6. This was, of course, also the case for Euro-American widows up until the 19th century, at least those with some independent means: sexual freedom, because virginity was not at stake, as well as economic, public, and sometimes even political freedom.

7. Palm wine tapping is nothing new, but its more recent lucrative potential, given increased demand from across the Senegalese border, has fueled a dramatic increase in higher-risk tapping among the Jola male population.

8. In some ways, this story—I was never able to determine the extent to which it was imagined or real—is an interesting twist on the "poison bride" trope in widowhood literature. For an account that brings to the fore the perception of women's interest in men's

wealth, and thus their motivation to kill their husbands, see Nyanzi, Emodu-Walakira, and Serwaniko (2009).

9. Here is where I have found resonance for this admittedly provocative proposition even far from the rice paddies of Guinea-Bissau. In various presentations of this material, when I have suggested the notion that wives might fantasize about widowhood, I get knowing chuckles from married women in the audience, perhaps revealing what Barbara Myerhoff (1980, 246) called "laughter . . . aroused by the embarrassment of instant recognition."

10. Sarah Lamb (1999) noted a similar response among Indian widows considering remarriage.

11. I thank Misty Bastian for helping me develop this point.

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Joanna Davidson
Department of Anthropology
Boston University
232 Bay State Road
Boston, MA 02215
jhdavid@bu.edu